

On Reading Well

Notes toward a practice of attentive reading

There is a difference between reading a text and merely moving your eyes across it. The first is a conversation; the second is a form of politeness. Most of what we call reading in daily life belongs to the second category, and there is nothing wrong with that — timetables, receipts and news briefs do not ask to be argued with. But some texts do ask. They put forward a claim about the world, and the honest response is not to nod along but to stop, push back, and write something down.

The oldest technology for this is the margin. Readers have always crowded the edges of their books with objections, summaries, exclamation marks and small drawings. These marks — marginalia — are not decoration. They are the visible trace of a mind at work, and rereading them years later is often more revealing than rereading the text itself.

A good annotation practice has two movements. The first is fast and physical: you underline, you star, you highlight. This costs almost nothing and marks the terrain. The second is slow and deliberate: you take one of the marked passages and ask what, exactly, it made you think. This second movement needs room — more room than a margin can give. It needs a blank page of its own, sitting right next to the passage that provoked it, so the eye can travel between the author's words and your own.

That adjacency matters more than it seems. When notes live in a separate notebook, the connection between thought and source decays within weeks; you find a sentence in your own handwriting and can no longer say what it answers. When the note is anchored to the passage — when clicking the one summons the other — the pair survives together. The passage keeps the note honest, and the note keeps the passage alive.

None of this requires discipline so much as it requires furniture. A desk where the book can lie open; a page beside it that is always blank; a way of marking that costs one gesture, not five. If the tools are right, annotation stops feeling like homework and starts feeling like what it is: thinking, caught in the act.

What follows, then, is a modest proposal for the reader of digital documents. Treat the PDF not as a picture of a text but as a working surface. Mark it in colour. Disagree with it in writing. Let every strong passage carry your reply beside it. A document read this way is never finished — and that is the point.

A short exercise

Pick any sentence on the first page that strikes you as either obviously true or obviously wrong. Select it. Give it a colour. Then open the notebook page beside it and answer three questions: What is the author actually claiming? What would have to be true for the claim to hold? And where, in your own experience, has it held or failed?

Write until the page pushes back. The first two sentences of any note are usually a summary; the thought you were after tends to arrive in the third. If you stop early, you keep the summary and lose the thought.

When you return to this document next month, do not reread the essay. Read your notes first. They are the record of what this text did to you — which is the only part of reading that was ever yours.